

Architecture as Ideas

Seven buildings, each making a different claim about what a building is for.

1. The Parthenon

447–432 BCE · Pentelic marble · The Acropolis, Athens

The Parthenon was built as a temple to Athena at the height of Athenian power. Its reputation rests on proportion: the relationships between its parts were tuned to a system of ratios meant to express order itself. The columns swell slightly towards the middle and lean inward, and the platform curves upward at its centre, so that almost nothing in the building is truly straight. These refinements correct the eye, and a structure full of subtle curves reads as perfectly regular. The claim the Parthenon makes is that beauty is mathematical, and that a building should embody a harmony the mind recognises even when the eye cannot name it.

Well building hath three conditions: firmness, commodity, and delight. — Vitruvius, rendered by Sir Henry Wotton (1624)

They were created in a short time for all time; for in beauty each of them was, even at that time, ancient, but in the freshness of its vigour it is, even to the present day, recent and newly made. — Plutarch, Life of Pericles

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Parthenon”; a clear view of the west front shows the columns best.*

2. Chartres Cathedral

c. 1194–1220 · Limestone and stained glass · Chartres, France

When the earlier cathedral at Chartres burned in 1194, it was rebuilt within a single generation, which gives it an unusual unity for a Gothic building. Gothic structure, the pointed arch, the rib vault and the flying buttress, let masons carry the weight of the roof on a skeleton of stone, so the walls no longer had to hold the building up. Freed of that task, the walls could be opened into vast windows. Chartres keeps most of its original medieval glass, so the interior is washed in coloured light. For its builders this was not decoration but theology: light standing for the divine, and the building offered as a model of heaven on earth.

The dull mind rises to truth through that which is material. — Abbot Suger, On the Abbey Church of St-Denis (12th century)

No good work whatever can be perfect, and the demand for perfection is always a sign of a misunderstanding of the ends of art. — John Ruskin, The Stones of Venice (1853)

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Chartres Cathedral interior” for the nave and glass; “Chartres Cathedral west façade” for the exterior.*

3. The Sagrada Família

1882–2026 · Stone · Antoni Gaudí · Barcelona

Gaudí took charge of the Sagrada Família in 1883 and worked on it until his death in 1926, when he was struck by a tram on his way to church. He left it far from finished, and it has been built ever since from his models and drawings; the central tower was completed in February 2026, as the centenary of his death approached, making it the tallest church in the world. Gaudí designed it by studying nature rather than older buildings. His columns branch like trees to hold the roof, his towers echo seed pods and termite mounds, and he found his structures by hanging weighted strings to see which shapes stand up on their own. The building argues that the deepest source for architecture is not the past but the natural world, and behind that, for Gaudí, its creator.

Originality consists in returning to the origin. — Antoni Gaudí

Those who look for the laws of nature as a support for their new works collaborate with the creator. — Antoni Gaudí

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Sagrada Família” for the exterior; “Sagrada Família nave” shows the tree-like columns, which are the point.*

4. Casa Batlló

1904–1906 · Remodelled apartment building · Antoni Gaudí · Barcelona

Casa Batlló is a remodelling rather than a new building: Gaudí took an ordinary apartment block and reworked its façade and interior into something that looks grown rather than built. The front has no straight lines. The balconies resemble bone or mask, the pillars look like limbs, the roof curves like the back of an animal, and the whole surface is covered in broken tiles that shift colour as the light moves. Locals call it the “house of bones.” Where the Sagrada Família turns nature into structure, Casa Batlló turns it into surface and feeling, treating a home as a living body rather than a container.

The straight line belongs to men, the curved line to God. — Antoni Gaudí

There are no straight lines or sharp corners in nature. Therefore, buildings must have no straight lines or sharp corners. — Antoni Gaudí

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Casa Batlló façade” for the bone balconies; “Casa Batlló roof” for the animal-back ridge.*

5. Haus Wittgenstein

1926–1928 · Ludwig Wittgenstein with Paul Engelmann · Vienna

The philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein designed this house for his sister, working with the architect Paul Engelmann. He had no architectural training, but he gave the project the same exactness he brought to philosophy. There is no ornament, no carpet or curtain, nothing soft; the proportions of the rooms were calculated precisely, and Wittgenstein designed the door handles, window catches and radiators himself rather than accept anything ready-made. Near the end he had a ceiling raised by three centimetres to settle a room's proportions. The house tests an idea: that a building, like a sentence, can be stripped to exactly what it needs and no more. His sister admired it and admitted she could not imagine living in it.

Architecture is a gesture. Not every purposive movement of the human body is a gesture, and no more is every building designed for a purpose architecture. — Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Culture and Value*

The evolution of culture marches with the elimination of ornament from useful objects. — Adolf Loos, *Ornament and Crime* (1908)

Less is more. / Less is a bore. — Mies van der Rohe; and the reply from Robert Venturi

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Haus Wittgenstein” or “Stonborough House” for the exterior and the bare interior.*

6. The Barbican Estate

1965–1976 · Reinforced concrete · Chamberlin, Powell and Bon · City of London

The Barbican is a housing estate and arts centre built on a part of London flattened by bombing in the Second World War. It is the best-known British example of Brutalism, a style whose name comes from *béton brut*, French for raw concrete. Its surfaces were left rough and unpainted, hammered by hand to expose the stone within, and its towers and walkways were planned as a complete city in miniature, lifting people above the street. Brutalism was an architecture of conviction, often used for housing, universities and civic buildings, and it carried a moral claim: that a building should show honestly what it is made of and how it was made. Much of the public has always found it ugly, which makes it a useful case for asking whether ugliness is a fair charge against a building or beside the point.

Brutalism tries to face up to a mass-production society, and drag a rough poetry out of the confused and powerful forces which are at work. — Reyner Banham, *The New Brutalism* (1955)

A monstrous carbuncle on the face of a much-loved and elegant friend. — Charles, then Prince of Wales, attacking a proposed modern building (1984)

[INSERT IMAGE HERE] *Wikimedia Commons “Barbican Estate”; views of the towers and the raised walkways show the raw concrete best.*